



RESTORATIONESSENTIALS

Factory-Correct Restoration Reference

Jeep Grand Wagoneer (1984–91) Restoration Guide

Model Year 1984–91

Model	Jeep Grand Wagoneer (SJ), Toledo-built
Engine	AMC 360 cu in (5.9L) V8, 144 hp, 2-barrel
Driveline	TorqueFlite 727 auto; NP229 Selec-Trac
Production	1984–91; 1,560 built in final year 1991
Notable	Woodgrain luxury 4x4; Final Edition 1991

Every specification in this guide was checked against factory literature, marque references, period road tests, and documented survivor cars. Where sources disagree or the record is silent, this guide says so rather than guessing.

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Chapter 1 — The Grand Wagoneer: The Luxury 4x4 That Would Not Die

The SJ Wagoneer ran from 1963 to 1991 without a major body-panel change — Brooks Stevens' box outlived the company that designed it. When the downsized Wagoneer arrived for 1984, demand for the big one kept it in production as the Grand Wagoneer, and it became the original luxury SUV in the years the market was inventing the idea. Chrysler bought AMC in March 1987 and, wisely, changed almost nothing but the build quality. This guide covers the 1984–91 Grand Wagoneer: one body, one engine that matters, and a restoration whose signature task has nothing to do with metal — the woodgrain.

Chapter 2 — What Makes 1984–91 Different

- **Grand Wagoneer vs. the earlier SJ:** same body, luxury specification — and the name only exists from 1984.
- **The Custom experiment:** a de-contented, woodgrain-free Grand Wagoneer Custom for 1984, dropped for 1985 — the market had spoken.
- **V8 only from 1987:** the base six was dropped, leaving the 360 standard for the rest of the run.
- **Chrysler era:** from March 1987 — sunroof in 1988, redesigned A/C compressor in 1989, minivan-sourced overhead console, and tightened build quality.



Chapter 3 — VIN Decoding and Year Identification

The 17-character VINs of the era are documented in the marque charts; real cars anchor them. A documented 1988 reads 1JCNJ15U8JT233689 and the 1989 cars 1J4GS5872KP100628 — the year letter (J for 1988, K for 1989) sits in its standard position, the engine digit names the 360, and the prefix change across the decade reflects the AMC-to-Chrysler paperwork transition. Decode with the chart that matches the prefix in front of you, and photograph the plate before anything else — on a vehicle whose body never changed, the VIN is the model year.

Chapter 4 — The AMC 360: The Only Engine That Matters Here

The Grand Wagoneer's engine is the AMC 360-cubic-inch (5.9L) V8 with a two-barrel carburetor, rated at 144 hp in the documented 1988–89 specification — a lazy, torquey OHV V8 tuned to move a heavy luxury wagon without ever hurrying. The 258 six served the first years (to 1986); everything after is the 360. Restoration doctrine: the emissions-era vacuum and thermal plumbing around this engine is a system, not clutter — it is mapped, photographed, and restored as a system, because the NP229's vacuum controls live in the same neighborhood (Chapter 5) and 'cleaned-up' engine bays are where four-wheel drive goes to stop engaging.

Chapter 5 — Transmission and the NP229 Selec-Trac

Behind the 360 sits the three-speed TorqueFlite 727 automatic (the marque service literature's specification for the SJ line) and the NP229 Selec-Trac transfer case — two-wheel drive, four-high, and four-low from the floor selector, with a viscous coupling for full-time manners. The system's known restoration trap is vacuum: engagement depends on vacuum motors and hoses that age out. A Grand Wagoneer that will not engage 4WD usually needs hoses and actuators, in that order — test the vacuum system before pricing a transfer case.

Chapter 6 — Axles, Suspension, Brakes, and Steering

The SJ rides on leaf springs and solid axles. The Dana 44 front is the documented SJ fitment; the rear axle is a running-change item across the long SJ run (Dana 44 in the line's earlier pattern, AMC 20 appearing later) — this guide does not guess: identify the housing on the car in front of you and order for it. Power front discs and rear drums, power steering, and the 15-inch turbine alloy wheels with 235/75R15 tires documented on the Final Edition cars complete the running gear.

Chapter 7 — Woodgrain: The Signature Restoration

The Grand Wagoneer is identified at fifty paces by its vinyl woodgrain appliqué and the simulated-wood framing trim around it. Restoring it is the model's signature task: the vinyl's pattern, tone, and border treatment are year-specific reference items, the framing sections are a separate material with its own damage modes (cracking, delamination, moisture trapped behind), and the metal underneath the appliqué is a rust trap that must be inspected before new vinyl covers it again. Sequence matters more than product choice: metal first, documented pattern second, framing restored or reproduced to match — and the whole job photographed for the file, because the next buyer will ask.



Chapter 8 — Interior and the Luxury Equipment

The Grand Wagoneer sold luxury in SJ years: leather-and-cloth seating, power seats, windows, locks, and rear liftgate window, cruise control, tilt column, and — on the late cars — the overhead console with its compass. The restoration traps are the powered ones: window motors and regulators, the power rear window's mechanism in the liftgate, and thirty years of switch and motor aging across every door. The A/C system changed mid-run (compressor redesigned for 1989) — identify the system before ordering parts against the model year.

Chapter 9 — Production Numbers and the Final Edition

Figure	Count	Note
SJ Wagoneer run	1963–1991	29 model years, one body
Grand Wagoneer name	1984–1991	the years this guide covers
1991 production	1,560	final year
Hunter Green 1991	~150	rarest final-year color
Last Grand Wagoneer	June 21, 1991	Hunter Green car

The last batch wore an optional 'Final Edition' dash badge. 1991s are the collector summit; every Grand Wagoneer, though, is a 1984–91 body with a 1963 silhouette and a rising market — condition and documentation decide value inside the run far more than year does.

Chapter 10 — Rust-Prone Areas and Inspection Guide

SJ rust: floor pans, rocker panels, the rear quarter and wheel-arch 'dogleg' ahead of the rear wheels, the tailgate/liftgate surround, and the frame's rear section. Add the woodgrain trap (Chapter 7): moisture lives behind the vinyl and its framing, so the appliqué comes into the inspection, not just the estimate. Magnet, light, photographs, notes — before negotiation (Chapter 14).

Chapter 11 — Restoration Sequence for the Grand Wagoneer

- **1. Document** — VIN plate (the model year lives there), engine and drivetrain identification, photographs of the woodgrain and framing as found.
- **2. Name the Jeep honestly** — year by VIN, engine by casting, rear axle by housing. The body will not help you; it never changed.
- **3. Metal first** — floors, rockers, doglegs, and the steel under the woodgrain, repaired before any vinyl is discussed.
- **4. Drivetrain as a system** — the 360's vacuum and emissions plumbing mapped and restored with the NP229's controls, not around them.
- **5. Power equipment proven** — every motor, regulator, and the liftgate window, before trim goes back on.
- **6. Woodgrain and trim last**, to the documented year pattern, and photographed for the file.



Chapter 12 — Engine Specifications at a Glance

Item	Grand Wagoneer (1984–91)
Engine	AMC 360 cu in (5.9L) V8, OHV
Rating	144 hp (documented 1988–89 spec)
Induction	2-barrel carburetor
Transmission	3-speed automatic (TorqueFlite 727)
Transfer case	NP229 Selec-Trac (2WD/4HI/4LO)
Wheels/tires	15-in turbine alloy; 235/75R15

Chapter 13 — Options and Model-Year Changes

- 1984: Grand Wagoneer name begins; Custom (no-woodgrain) variant tried and dropped for 1985.
- 1987: six-cylinder dropped — 360 V8 only; Chrysler ownership from March 1987.
- 1988: electric sunroof available; overhead console arrives in the late cars.
- 1989: A/C compressor redesigned — parts differ by year.
- 1991: Final Edition dash badge on the last batch; 1,560 built.

Chapter 14 — Buyer Inspection Checklist

- VIN decoded to year and engine — the body proves nothing; it was unchanged for 29 years.
- Steel under the woodgrain inspected; vinyl condition and framing integrity assessed separately from paint.
- 4WD engagement tested on the vacuum system first (Chapter 5) before transfer-case conclusions.
- Every power accessory functioned — windows, locks, seats, liftgate glass — with failures itemized.
- Floors, rockers, doglegs, liftgate surround, and rear frame mapped with photos.
- Rear axle housing identified in person (running-change item).
- 1991 cars: Final Edition badge and documentation checked; Hunter Green rarity claims paper-verified.

Chapter 15 — Casting Numbers, Codes, and Date Codes

The AMC 360's castings and date codes read against the marque engine references; the flagship rule applies — castings precede the build and sit close. The Chrysler-era cars are identified by VIN rather than by any body cue, which makes the dash plate's preservation a restoration item in itself: photograph it, protect it during bodywork, and keep its decode in the car's file.

Chapter 16 — Clones, Customs, and Tells That Matter

The Grand Wagoneer fraud pattern is gentle compared to muscle cars — it is condition fraud, not identity fraud: woodgrain vinyl laid over unrepaired rust, 'Final Edition' badges on 1990 cars, Chrysler-era equipment backdated into AMC years. The tells: the VIN's year letter against every year-specific claim (sunroof, A/C system, console), the metal under the appliqué, and the vacuum system's honesty — a Jeep whose 4WD engages and whose liftgate glass works has been maintained by someone who maintained everything.



Chapter 17 — Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources

No torque value is printed that cannot be traced to factory service literature. The discipline stands: clean chased threads, lubrication as the manual specifies, the printed pattern in at least three steps, re-checks after the first heat cycle where called for — and factory values for body-mount, spring, and steering hardware. Values come from the Jeep service literature in Sources; record what you used.

Recommended for this restoration

Shop exact-fit supplies on Amazon

- Jeep Grand Wagoneer factory service manual
- AMC 360 V8 engine rebuild kit
- Jeep Grand Wagoneer woodgrain restoration kit
- Jeep SJ Wagoneer parts catalog

As an Amazon Associate, RestorationEssentials earns from qualifying purchases made through these links.

Sources Consulted

Every specification in this guide was checked against published references before printing. Where sources disagree, this guide says so in the text rather than picking a number silently. The references below are the backbone of the technical chapters:

- **Jeep factory literature.** the Jeep service manuals and dealer ordering information for the SJ line — authority for torque values, specifications, and equipment definitions
- **Hagerty Media Grand Wagoneer history and valuation research.** the model-year history (Custom's deletion, the six's end, the Chrysler era), documented VINs, and the 144-hp 360 specification
- **Final Edition market documentation.** the 1,560-unit 1991 run, June 21 1991 final build, Final Edition badge, and Hunter Green rarity
- **Marque (SJ) technical references.** transfer-case, axle, and running-change documentation for the 1963–91 SJ line

A note on numbers. Factory literature, period road tests, and marque historians do not always agree — production totals, horsepower ratings, and paint codes all have documented conflicts. This guide uses the best-supported figure in each case and flags the conflict where one exists, so you can judge for yourself.



Thank You

Thank you for choosing this RestorationEssentials guide. Whether this is your first Jeep Grand Wagoneer (1984–91) or your fiftieth, you picked one of the great ones, and the fact that you are doing your homework before you turn a wrench puts you ahead of most of the field.

These cars survived because people like you refused to let them disappear. Every correct fastener, every properly decoded tag, every hour spent getting the details right keeps the history honest for the next owner and the next generation of enthusiasts.

Twenty-nine years of one honest box — the luxury SUV before the category had a name. Keep its woodgrain straight, its vacuum lines honest, and its VIN legible, and it will outlast another generation.

If this guide helped your build, we would love to hear about it. Good luck with the restoration, and enjoy every mile.

— The RestorationEssentials Team